

To: County of Vulcan Council

April 10, 2026

Subject: Request for Visual Impact Assessment – Proposed Palliser Grid AI Data Centre Campus - Bylaw 2026-007

Dear Members of Council,

I am writing regarding the proposed land use re-designation from rural to industrial for the proposed AI Data Center Campus – Bylaw 2026-007.

Section 13.1 of the County's Land Use Bylaw clearly states that industrial developments in proximity to sensitive areas must not be unsightly or offensive. I understand that the proponent has now indicated that berming and tree planting will be used to mitigate the visual impact of the proposed industrial development.

This proposal fails to account for the topographical realities of the site (see topography map and photo of the steep grade at end of this letter). The subject lands are situated on a prominent hillside with an approximate vertical elevation gain of 25 metres (82 feet). When combined with the proposed 35-foot structure, effective visual screening would require a berm approaching 120 feet in height. Such a measure is patently unreasonable and impractical, thereby underscoring the significant and unavoidable visual impact of the development, which will remain both prominent and detrimental to the surrounding landscape.

In this case, the effectiveness of berming is central to determining whether the proposal complies with that standard. At present, this appears to be based solely on the proponent's assertion, rather than on objective, verifiable evidence.

Given the importance of this issue, I respectfully request that Council require the applicant to submit a **professional visual impact assessment** prior to making a final decision. Such a study should include:

- Cross-sectional drawings illustrating proposed berm heights relative to surrounding viewpoints
- Line-of-sight analysis from key public and residential vantage points
- Photo simulations or visual renderings of the fully developed site
- Existing and proposed elevation data

See example below of an AI visualization of a 35 ft tall data center and natural gas power generating facility that is one mile long and on the proposed land. Overlay picture taken from LBR boat lockers facing north towards Southern Alberta Bible Camp.

An AI example of visualization of the proposed Data Center's impact on the reservoir



Without this type of visual impact information, it is difficult to see how Council can confidently determine compliance with Section 13.1 or ensure that its decision is well-supported and defensible.

This request is intended to ensure that Council has the necessary information to make a fully informed decision that aligns with its own bylaws and the long-term interests of the community.

To that end, I would also recommend that Vulcan County consider engaging the services of the Oldman River Regional Services Commission. As an independent body, they are well positioned to provide an objective assessment and informed recommendations to Council, supporting a well-considered decision regarding the proposed land use re-designation.

Their evaluation and feedback would also be of interest to surrounding landowners and could enhance transparency if shared in advance of Council's final decision on the rezoning.

Secondly, LBR is not opposed to responsible development within the region. As a matter of fact, LBR has not intervened in prior developments, including multiple wind energy projects and the Travers Solar Farm, from which Vulcan County has derived substantial tax revenue. Notwithstanding this, the LBR community has borne the cumulative impacts of such developments with minimal, if any, corresponding benefit. Community benefit commitments previously advanced by project proponents have ultimately proven to be illusory. The result has been a permanently altered landscape, to the detriment of the natural prairie environment and its visual character.

The proposed Palliser Grid project is, fundamentally, inappropriately sited. It is located in close proximity to environmentally sensitive and recreational lands - areas that are expressly protected under existing County policy. Viable and more appropriate alternative locations exist to the northeast, which would place the project at a greater distance from these protected areas. Additionally, these locations would consolidate the project within an already industrialized area (adjacent to existing wind and solar developments) thus reducing the cumulative effects of industrialization.

In a project of this scale, land acquisition costs are comparatively insignificant. Site selection should not be driven by the convenience of land ownership by the proponent. Rather, a suitable and appropriate location should be identified, and the proponent, acting in accordance with standard development practices, should acquire or lease the necessary lands.

There is an inherent cost associated with environmental stewardship, and this matter represents a critical threshold. The cumulative effects of existing wind and solar developments, combined with the proposed data centre and associated power infrastructure, are substantial and concerning. The continued approval of such projects in sensitive areas risks the complete erosion of remaining natural landscapes and sensitive environmental eco-structure. A comparison of the region's landscape over the past decade clearly demonstrates significant and irreversible change that has occurred.

The proposed project is fundamentally mis-located and should not be expedited nor advanced through political means.

I also request that this correspondence be included in the official record for Bylaw 2026-007.

Thank you for your attention to this matter. I look forward to your response.

Sincerely,

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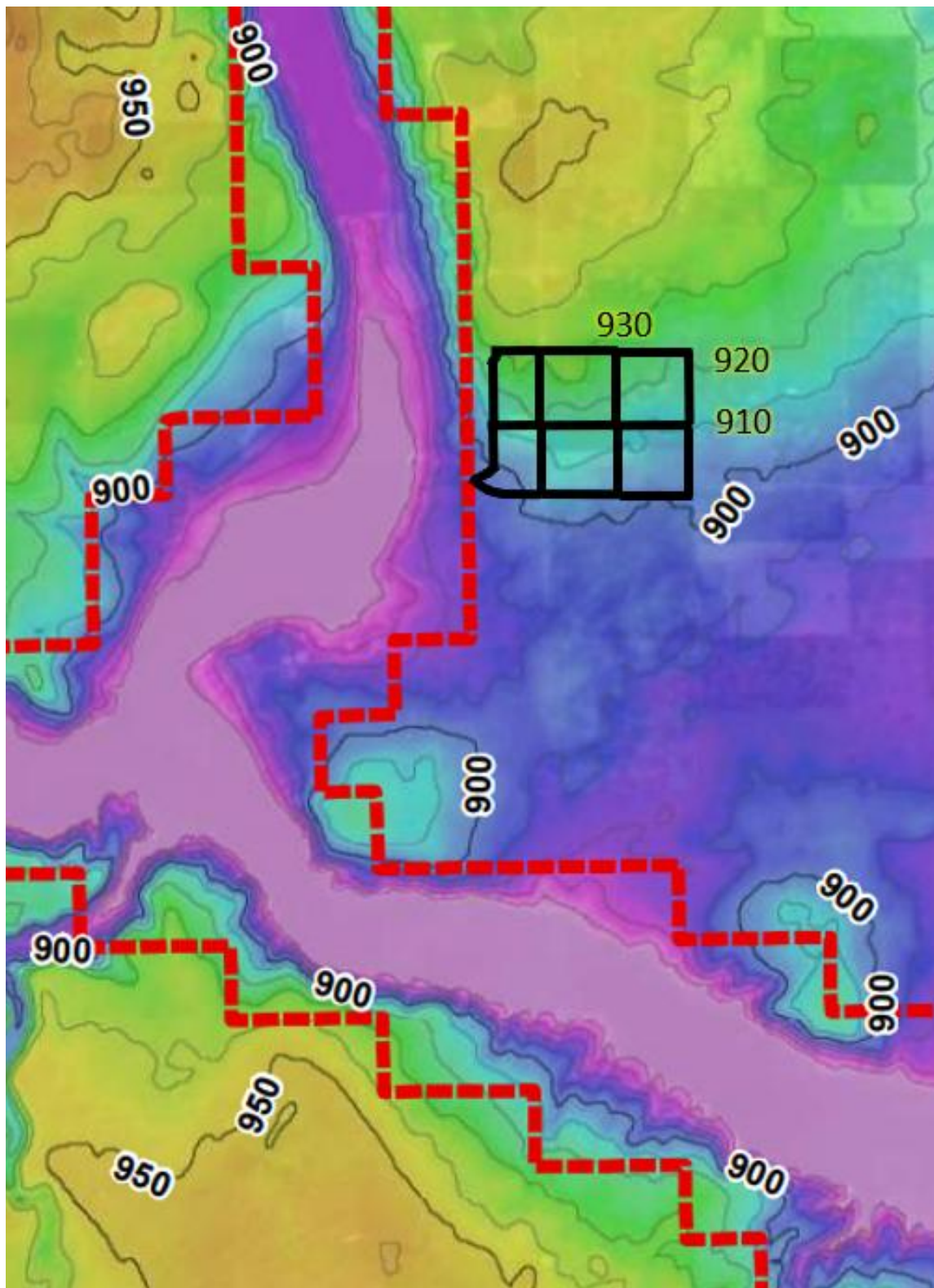
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Topography map as sourced from the Vulcan County Reservoir Area Structure Plan 2020-015

Proposed land use change area approximated in black outline.



Picture taken at top of hill at approximate 930m contour line showing steep grade of area. Note semi-truck at intersection for relative size comparison.

